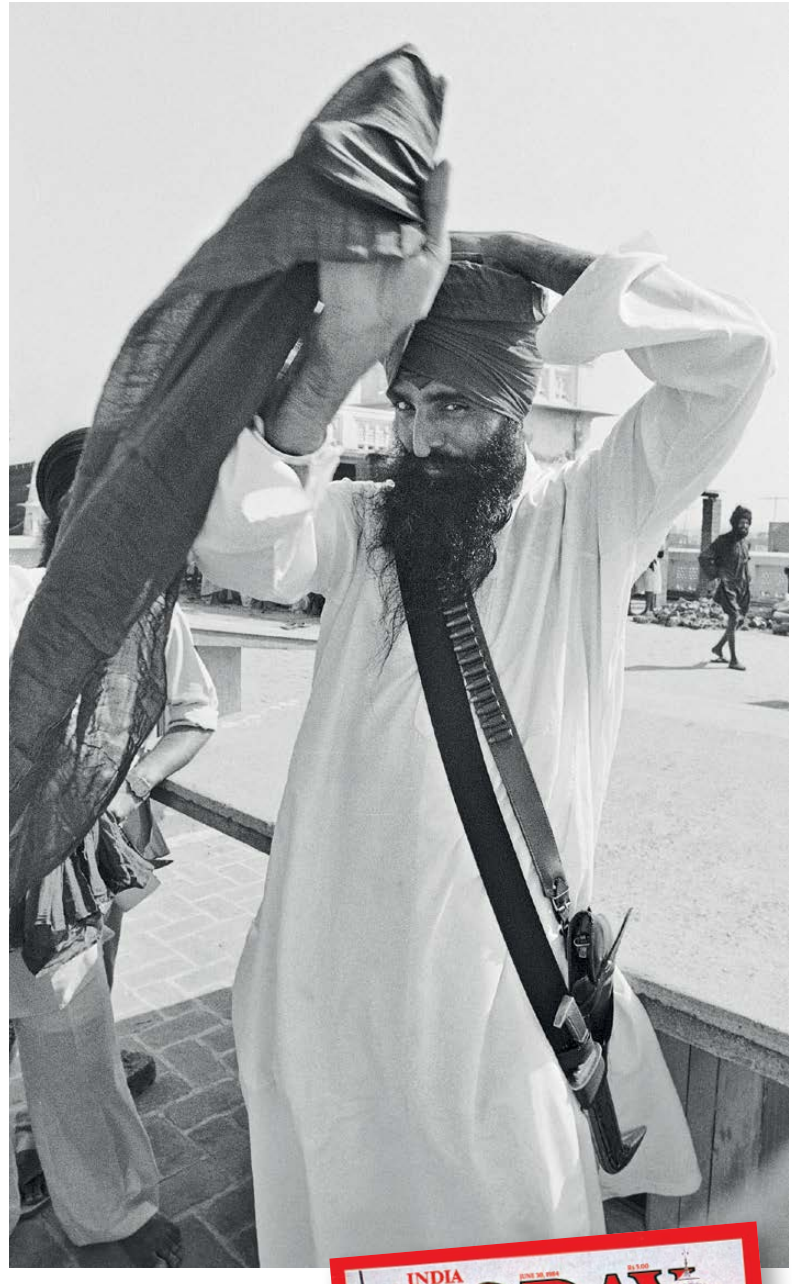
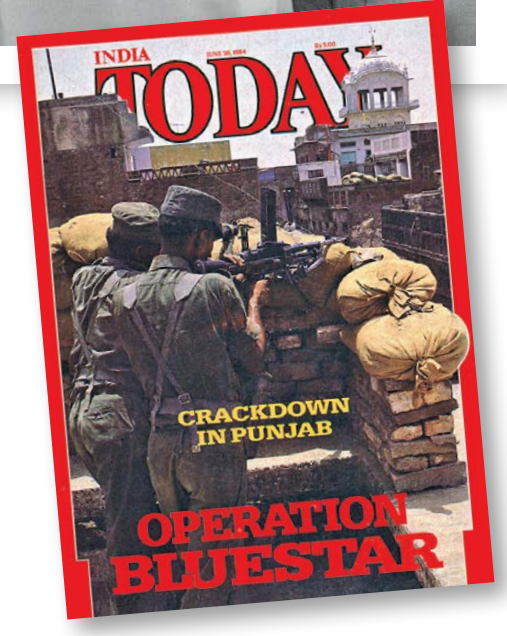
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BHAWAN SINGH





Punjab's precipitous plunge into political and religious unreason and cruelty in the 1980s hasn't lost the power to shock. Its origins lay in a clutch of socio-economic, territorial and riparian demands articulated in the Anandpur Sahib resolution (1973) and its later iterations. The Shiromani Akali Dal's sticking to these and its opposition to the Emergency led the Congress regime to prop up a rabblerousing young chief of the Damdami Taksal seminary, Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale—who exhorted Sikhs to lead a traditional life and inveighed against Hindus—as a counterbalance. As hotheads trotted out the old demand of Khalistan, Bhindranwale expertly played the Centre and Akalis against each other. A bloody clash with the Nirankari sect (1978) gained him thousands of fanatical followers, and his farcical arrest and release after the killing of Lala Jagat Narain (1981) gave him an aura of invincibility.